

DISANN KATENDE, MPH

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September 22, 2026

Hiring Committee

Information Management Strategy and Policy Branch, Digital and Analytics Strategy Division
Ontario Ministry of Health

Re: Information Management Policy Analyst — Job ID 247975

I am writing to apply for the Information Management Policy Analyst position with the Information Management Strategy and Policy Branch. I am a research epidemiologist and public health data analyst with 12 years of experience turning health data and research evidence into recommendations for policy, program, and funding decisions, most recently as a Research Epidemiologist with the World Health Organization and previously with First Nations Health Authority, BC Children's Hospital Research Institute, and CAREX Canada at the BC Centre for Disease Control. I am based in Toronto and would welcome the opportunity to bring that experience, and a direct, working understanding of how health data is collected, linked, and governed, to the Branch's data strategy and policy work.

As Pacific Region Representative on the CIHR/PHAC Community Advisory Committee, I advise CIHR and PHAC on community-identified research priorities and provide strategic feedback on research proposals and funding priorities that shape a national funder's policy direction. I convene and lead consultations with community leaders, researchers, and health experts, synthesizing their input into recommendations for senior decision-makers; the same policy research, stakeholder consultation, and information-synthesis work this role asks for, applied to health data strategy instead of research funding.

I also bring direct experience leading research that gets used for policy-relevant recommendations. At CAREX Canada, I led studies on occupational and environmental exposure risks — including carcinogen exposure among new and immigrant workers and lead in BC school drinking water, producing evidence used to inform exposure-reduction recommendations, while working with linked administrative datasets of more than 100 million records and assessing their quality and limitations so findings could support sound conclusions. As Senior Coordinator at First Nations Health Authority, I led the BC First Nations Regional Health Survey, negotiating data-governance and logistics arrangements across community and organizational stakeholders to deliver it on schedule under OCAP-compliant data management, and building the relationships and consensus-building this role calls for in engaging ministry partners and external stakeholders on data governance.

My technical grounding in SQL, R, SAS, Python, and health-data governance (OCAP-compliant data management, Statistics Canada's Secure Research Environment) means I bring a practitioner's understanding of the data landscape this Branch is setting policy for, not just a policy generalist's view of it. Combined with a peer-reviewed publication record and experience organizing complex technical findings for non-technical and executive audiences, I can move quickly from data-strategy questions to workable policy options.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my background in policy-relevant research, stakeholder consultation, and health data governance can support the Branch's work. I appreciate your consideration.

Sincerely,

Disann Katende, MPH

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PROFILE

Research epidemiologist and health data analyst with 12 years' experience turning health data and research evidence into recommendations for policy, program, and funding decisions, across Canada's public health, research, and Indigenous health sectors and international health agencies. Direct experience leading research and analysis to inform policy positions, consulting with and convening stakeholder groups, and presenting complex, technical findings clearly to decision-makers. Comfortable working independently in ambiguous, fast-moving environments and translating data-strategy questions into workable recommendations.

COMPETENCIES

- Policy development, research & analysis: leads research and analysis using varied methods and sources, including stakeholder consultation, to synthesize evidence-informed policy options and recommendations; strong literature review and evidence-appraisal skills; peer-reviewed publication record
- Political acuity, relationship building & consensus-building: builds and maintains working relationships with internal and external stakeholders at all levels; negotiates across community, organizational, and government lines to align interests and reach agreement
- Strategic thinking & innovation: applies a systems view across health data, technology, and policy; identifies creative approaches to long-standing data-strategy and health-system problems
- Leadership & project management: leads projects and cross-functional, multidisciplinary teams; structured approach to organizing and delivering multiple concurrent initiatives
- Technical grounding: SQL, R, SAS, Python, ArcGIS Pro, QGIS; OCAP-compliant data governance and Statistics Canada Secure Research Environment protocols; informs policy analysis with direct knowledge of how health data is collected, linked, and governed

EXPERIENCE

Pacific Region Representative | *CIHR/PHAC Community Advisory Committee, Remote (Toronto)* Feb 2026 – Present

- Advise CIHR and PHAC on community-identified research priorities and emerging public health issues affecting Black, Caribbean, and African Canadian communities, and provide strategic feedback on research proposals and funding priorities that directly shapes a national funder's policy direction
- Convene and lead consultation with community leaders, researchers, and health experts to gather input on research priorities and policy development, synthesizing community perspective into recommendations for senior decision-makers at CIHR and PHAC

Research Epidemiologist | *World Health Organization – Vaccination against Emerging and Neglected Infectious Diseases*, Jan 2025 – Present

- Lead spatial analysis of Onchocerciasis mass drug administration coverage across 238 clusters in Southern Malawi, synthesizing findings into assessments that inform program and policy decisions with in-country partners
- Build coverage-monitoring [dashboards](#) that organize complex surveillance data into clear, decision-ready information for program leadership
- Lead author on a coverage-survey manuscript (in preparation) analyzing 8,019 participants across 238 clusters in 8 districts

Methodologist | *Smart Discharges, Institute for Global Health, BC Children's Hospital, Vancouver, BC* Nov 2024 – Dec 2025

- Developed predictive models and survival analyses of post-discharge outcomes for under-5 pediatric sepsis across East African hospital sites

Research Analyst | *CAREX Canada, BC Centre for Disease Control – UBC, Vancouver, BC* Oct 2022 – Jan 2025

- Led research and analysis on occupational and environmental exposure risks — carcinogen exposure among new and immigrant workers, lead in BC school drinking water, sun-safety practices among Toronto lifeguards — producing evidence used to inform exposure-reduction recommendations for public health and workplace-safety audiences
- Analyzed exposure–disease associations using linked administrative datasets of more than 100 million records (StatCan Secure Research Environment: National Household Survey, Canadian Cancer Registry, CanCHEC), including a lead-authored study published in a peer-reviewed journal
- Assessed data quality, linkage limitations, and methodology considerations across multiple national data sources to ensure findings could support sound policy conclusions

Senior Coordinator, Data Collection and Analysis | *First Nations Health Authority, Vancouver, BC* Oct 2022 – Jan 2023

- Led design and implementation of the BC First Nations Regional Health Survey — planning the project, training and coordinating a field team of enumerators, and negotiating data-governance and logistics arrangements across community and organizational stakeholders to deliver the survey on schedule under OCAP-compliant data management

Data Analyst & Coordinator | *The Collaboration for Research Excellence in Africa (Core Africa–UK), Remote* Dec 2021 – Mar 2023

- Managed REDCap data collection and conducted SAS/R statistical analysis for cancer and nutrition research studies

Research Data Analyst | *BC Children's Hospital Research Institute, Vancouver, BC*

Aug 2020 – Aug 2021

- Conducted statistical analysis on pediatric metabolic conditions in R and managed study data for a Gabapentin randomized controlled trial

Earlier Experience | *UBC; World Vision International; SNV; UNICEF-Concern Worldwide, Uganda & South Sudan / Vancouver, BC* 2014 – 2021

- Health Data Research Network student intern (EHR data standards, secure data linkage); UBC guest lecturer and Sustainability Scholar; and five years of nutrition and health-systems roles in East Africa, including multi-sectoral needs assessments and coordination with Ministry of Health counterparts on nutrition, HIV, and health-systems strengthening (World Vision International Uganda), and GIS-based malnutrition-hotspot surveillance in South Sudanese refugee response sites (UNICEF-Concern Worldwide)

EDUCATION

Master of Public Health (MPH) — University of British Columbia

BSc, Food Science and Technology — Makerere University

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

- Katende D, Rydz E, Quinn EK, Heer E, Shrestha R, Fazel SS, Peters CE (2024). Overrepresentation of new workers in jobs with multiple carcinogen exposures in Canada. *Int J Environ Res Public Health*, 21(8):1013.
- Larsen K, Katende D, Shrestha R, Peters CE. Exploring socio-spatial inequities for lead in drinking water: An assessment of lead exposure for public schools in British Columbia (under review).